

DIGITAL INFRASTRUCTURE

AI Infrastructure from the Field: Takeaways from 2nd Annual Denver trip

We hosted an investor trip to Denver to explore AI infrastructure themes around data centers and enterprise fiber. Our trip included a data center tour and meetings with management from Flexential (private data center company) and Lumen (LUMN, Neutral). In general, hyperscaler AI infrastructure demand remains strong, with continued strengthening of data center pricing power. Meanwhile, widespread enterprise AI use and infrastructure demand remains nascent, but with increased optimism for future growth. Please see our detailed takeaways within.

Michael Ng, CFA

+1(212)902-8618 | michael.ng@gs.com
Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC

Zorayda Montemayor

+1(212)357-6403 |
zorayda.montemayor@gs.com
Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC

Lindsey Shema

+1(801)578-2673 |
lindsey.shema@gs.com
Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC

Flexential

During our 2026 Denver data center bus tour, we toured Flexential's Englewood site, an 18 MW air-cooled facility with ~150K square feet with near full occupancy supporting both traditional and AI workloads for both wholesale, multitenancy, and colocation customers. Per the company, the site supported a 60/40 ratio of AI/Non-AI workloads. We come away from our tour of Flexential's Englewood data center with a better understanding of long-term supply constraints across both data center equipment and power, which should continue to drive data center supply tightness supporting pricing power over the longer term.

We also hosted Q&A with Ryan Mallory, CEO; Sam Rudek, COO; Jacob Horr, SVP, Strategic Initiatives; Jack Faunce, VP, Procurement; and Tom Bailey, VP, Energy. Key takeaways include:

- **Data center supply/demand tightness continuing to strengthen pricing power.** Per the company, continued tightness between data center capacity supply & demand industry-wide has driven benefits to pricing through both new leases and renewals. For example, for leases on new capacity, Flexential described how it is seeing pricing per kilowatt approaching \$200 (and should trend towards \$250 later this year), relative to ~\$70 in 2021. As such, in order to benefit from the beneficial pricing environment, Flexential aims to avoid pre-selling new capacity further out than 9 months (e.g. Flexential's Atlanta Douglasville 2 site is 85% pre-sold, with final completion in 4Q27). For lease renegotiations (which the company begins 6-8 months in advance of lease endings), the company is able to negotiate 3-4% annual escalators for wholesale deals & 5-6% annual escalators on multi-tenancy deals. Flexential expects to

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continue to benefit from data center supply tightness on a forward basis given (a) ongoing constraints on power availability & supply chain components, and (b) data center opposition.

- **Supply chain constraints driving elongated lead times in new builds.** Per the company, Flexential is seeing industry-wide supply chain constraints, with the greatest lead times on substations (4 years) and power generators (2 years). As such, the company is actively pre-ordering inventory to prepare for future deployments. Given widespread component constraints, Flexential expects new site builds to take ~3 years to complete, nearly double relative to 2021. Comparatively, Flexential estimates leasable capacity takes ~18 months to become available when the company acquires sites.
- **Large enterprise & hyperscale customer focus with long-term ROIC targets.** Per Flexential, it is increasingly focusing on serving multi-MW high-density multi-tenant and wholesale workloads, (44% of March 2026 MRR), where it estimates TAM is growing at a 19% 2024-2030 CAGR, and primarily serves large enterprise and hyperscale customers. That said, it continues to serve Enterprise Co-location services (smaller scale deployments below 1MW, 31% of March 2026 MRR), where it estimates its TAM growing at a 6% 2025-2030 CAGR. The majority of customer churn it sees today is largely smaller enterprises which decide to transition to the public cloud.

Lumen Technologies

At Lumen, we hosted Q&A with Chris Stansbury, President and CFO; Michael Reinke, SVP, Transformation Office; and Jim Breem, Investor Relations. Key takeaways include:

- **Positive reception of Networking-as-a-Service and cloud on-ramps.** Management highlighted that through Lumen's NaaS platform, clients can use its multi-cloud gateway offering to access its vast cloud on-ramps. They explained that this bypasses the need for enterprises to pay cross-connect fees to co-location centers, can significantly reduce latency, and improves security by creating entirely private connections that do not flow through the public internet. For reference, more than 20% of NaaS net adds in 1Q26 were from new customers and more than 60% were expanding their footprint with NaaS. They are also seeing lower churn from NaaS customers. Furthermore, management noted cloud partners have seen customers who use Lumen's direct cloud on-ramps scale faster.
- **Management sees strong outlook for East-West market, particularly once the proposed Alkira acquisition finalizes.** Management estimates a \$58bn TAM for East-West connectivity, growing at a ~13% CAGR. They stated that the recently announced Alkira acquisition (which they expect to finalize in 3Q26), would enable a cloud and carrier agnostic smart, programmable network and eliminate the time it would have taken to develop an in-house solution. Lumen's offering is primarily for enterprise customers. Management acknowledged enterprise use remains relatively nascent, but they see substantial growth potential for Lumen's offering as AI use scales. In addition to first mover advantage, management believes their competitive moat is Lumen's vast physical network. In fact, they explained that recent PCF deals

allow Lumen to expand its physical network concurrently with the almost entirely pre-paid hyperscaler builds, drastically reducing build-out costs. The proximity of Lumen's fiber to the hyperscalers also enables Lumen's multi-cloud gateways.

Price targets and risks

Valuation: We are Neutral rated on LUMN with a 12-month target price target of \$8.00 reflecting 6.00X NTM+1Y EBITDA.

Key risks: Upside risks: (1) Lumen could execute better on cost takeouts, driving margins, and EBITDA higher than consensus forecasts; (2) Revenue stabilization could come sooner than expected and this, coupled with improved margins, could drive significant upside to EBITDA and FCF forecasts; (3) A significant change in capital structure could be a material positive for the equity. Downside risks: (1) Lumen could find that incremental cost takeout opportunities are more difficult to achieve than currently expected; (2) Business fiber's structural headwinds may continue to limit Lumen's ability to turnaround revenue for longer; (3) Lumen could encounter fiercer competition from industry peers for incremental private connectivity fabric deals, limiting its ability to restructure.

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Contributing Authors: Michael Ng, CFA Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC, Zorayda Montemayor Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC, Lindsey Shema Goldman Sachs & Co. LLC.

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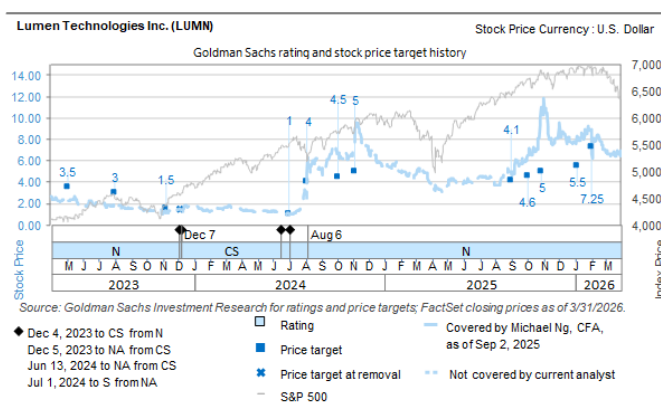
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Lumen Technologies Inc. (LUMN)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
06-May-26	8.00	9.81
04-Feb-26	7.25	6.63
06-Jan-26	5.50	8.30
31-Oct-25	5.00	10.28
03-Oct-25	4.60	6.56
02-Sep-25	4.10	4.79
06-Nov-24	5.00	9.02
04-Oct-24	4.50	6.78
07-Aug-24	4.00	6.63
01-Jul-24	1.00	1.11
09-Nov-23	1.50	1.18
02-Aug-23	3.00	1.79

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